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Graduate Admissions Committee
Department of Communications and New Media, National University of Singapore

October 2026

Re: PhD in Communications and New Media, August 2027 intake (NUS Research Scholarship)

Dear Committee members,

In my MSc I built a system to read public reaction to economic policy, and only later found that it had silently thrown away every comment written in Urdu or Hindi. That discovery is why I am applying to CNM. Large language models are now the default way to read political opinion from social media, yet we rarely check whether they read the same message the same way in Urdu script, Roman Urdu, English and Hinglish, or under the same story on YouTube and on Facebook. My proposal sits where CNM's computational and political communication meet: a test of whether LLM-labelled political opinion in Pakistan and India means the same across scripts and platforms, and whether it changes what we conclude when it does not.

Fit with CNM's faculty. Dr Subhayan Mukerjee's work with Yang and Peng on how engagement metrics shape news production on Facebook, and its replication on another platform, shows that platform matters on the producer side; my second study asks the same question of how audience reaction under the same stories is measured. Dr Zening Duan's work on how operationalisation changes what a text measure captures, and on comparison across YouTube and TikTok, is the basis for my first study on scripts. I have proposed Dr Mukerjee as advisor and Dr Duan as co-supervisor; the work of Associate Professors Taberez Neyazi and Kokil Jaidka on South Asian politics also informs the design.

A good Master's degree in a relevant discipline. I hold an MSc in Data Analytics with Distinction from the University of Portsmouth (master's project 78/100), studied as a Chevening Scholar. My dissertation compared public reaction to UK economic policy across 255,446 comments from X, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, under university ethics approval. Its weakness taught me most: the classifier had been checked against labels produced by a lexicon, so its apparent accuracy measured agreement, not truth.

Evidence of research experience. That lesson became a preprint with my supervisor, Dr Ella Haig, *Is the Platform Part of the Measurement?* (arXiv:2610.16757). It sets out a protocol for testing whether the platform acts as a source of measurement error and uses a known-truth simulation to show how pooling misleads when the platform mix shifts. It has not yet been applied to real data, and it is not peer reviewed; the PhD is its first real test. Model and prompt effects are already well documented (Baumann et al. 2025; Messing 2026), so my contribution is the South Asian script and platform test and a Roman Urdu political-stance gold set.

Quantitative and computational skills. For nearly eight years I have collected, labelled and analysed public online text. At Dubizzle Labs in Lahore I built the first web-data system for six products across nine Middle Eastern countries, in English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi, and was promoted twice. At M+C Saatchi Fluency in London I build LLM tagging and social listening for global brands and support work for UK government. As co-founder and CTO of Artemis AI I lead the architecture of a social media intelligence system for creators, where our own evaluation showed that agreement between models is not accuracy.

Why a PhD, and why now. Industry keeps giving me questions it cannot answer: whether a negative comment means the same thing on two platforms, whether a model reads Roman Urdu fairly, whether agreement between models is accuracy. I want the training to answer them properly, and to carry the results back to the people who rely on these numbers, from small businesses to public bodies in Pakistan, which is the promise I made in my Chevening application.

What I do not yet bring, and what I can offer. I have no peer-reviewed publication yet, and my training in communication theory and causal inference is limited; CNM's core modules in theory and methods are a main reason I am applying. In return, I can support teaching in social media analytics through the Graduate Assistantship Programme.

Practicalities. Both my degrees were taught in English. I am applying for the NUS Research Scholarship. My referees are Dr Ella Haig, Associate Professor in AI, University of Portsmouth, my dissertation supervisor and co-author, and Dr Fahad Ahmad, Senior Lecturer, University of Portsmouth, who taught and assessed me on the MSc. Thank you for considering my application.

Yours sincerely,
Asad Ikram